

US cuts all business ties with Harvard

Admissions and hiring called discriminatory, as battle continues to escalate

By Mike Damiano and Hilary Burns
GLOBE STAFF

After a weekend of threats and criticism from President Trump, the federal government on Tuesday severed the last of its remaining business ties to Harvard University.

Josh Gruenbaum, a top official at the US General Services Administration, instructed all federal agencies to terminate any contracts with Harvard or transfer them to other vendors. He also said in a letter sent to federal procurement officials Tuesday that government agencies should refrain from awarding any new contracts to Harvard in the future.

The letter effectively ends the government's decades-long business relationship with Harvard. It follows the termination of billions of dollars in research grants in recent months and represents the latest escalation in the Trump administration's extraordinary pressure campaign against the school.

The government has also launched an array of investigations, attempted to bar Harvard from enrolling foreign students, and moved to revoke the university's tax-exempt status, which could cost the school hundreds of millions of dollars.

Although the Trump administration's original rationale for targeting Harvard was campus antisemitism, Gruenbaum's letter Tuesday focused more on the government's allegations that Harvard's admissions and hiring practices violate antidiscrimination laws. For that reason, he said, Harvard should not be allowed to receive federal fund-

►US orders pause on interviews for student visas. **B1.**

HARVARD, Page A5

'Stress test' for endowment may bring a shift in strategy

By Diti Kohli
GLOBE STAFF

For a half-century, the Harvard Management Company has worked to make the wealthiest university in the world even wealthier.

The people who oversee the endowment, currently at \$53 billion, invest in everything from stocks to real estate trusts to grow the fund steadily, in the hope of supporting Harvard in perpetuity. Each year, Harvard taps a portion of its investment gains to fund 40 percent of operations — more than \$2 billion in 2024 — while leaving the principal intact.

Time and time again, Harvard officials have said the endowment is not a "piggy bank" or "rainy day fund" to be tapped in an emergency. But as the attacks from the White House intensify, will the school pivot?

Most recently, the Trump administration on Tuesday directed federal agencies to stop doing business with Harvard and to date has slashed the research funding it receives by around \$3 billion. Last week, Trump moved to bar international students — one-fourth of Harvard's student body and a valuable source of tuition — from campus; legis-

ENDOWMENT, Page A5

Reshaping health system his way

ROBERT F. KENNEDY JR.'S FIRST 100 DAYS



PETE KIEHART/NEW YORK TIMES

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. spoke last month about a CDC survey on autism, one of his main focuses.

Health secretary makes the call on dropping COVID boosters for many

By Helen Branswell
STAT

Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. announced Tuesday that he has unilaterally struck the recommendation that healthy children and healthy pregnant people get COVID-19 booster shots — a move experts say is unprecedented.

Kennedy made the announcement on the social media site X, flanked by Jay Bhattacharya, director of the National Institutes of Health, and Marty Makary, commissioner of the Food and Drug Administration.

"It's common sense, and it's good science," said Bhattacharya, whose agency has no involvement in the regulation of vaccines, or in decisions on who should get them.

Absent from the video was anyone from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, which sets policy for who should get approved vaccines on the advice of its expert panel, the Advisory Committee on Immunization Practices. The CDC is without an acting director.

The CDC's website still lists COVID vaccines in the pediatric vaccination schedule, the list of which vaccines chil-

COVID, Page A6

'People who want to be healthier, people who want to keep their kids healthy, are now getting very, very mixed messages about what might be safe.'

KATHLEEN SEBELIUS, who served as HHS secretary under President Barack Obama



ERIC LEE/NEW YORK TIMES

FDA Commissioner Marty Makary (left) and NIH Director Jay Bhattacharya are key players in Robert F. Kennedy's circle.

An unconventional approach

At the core of the "Make America Healthy Again" movement is scrutiny of ingredients in food, agricultural production, and vaccines, as well as a rejection of decades of scientific consensus. **A7.**

Kennedy confirms some critics' worst fears as he pushes his agenda, but wins support on food

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — When President Trump promised during the 2024 campaign to let Robert F. Kennedy Jr. "go wild on health," it was bound to result in scenes such as the one that unfolded at the White House on Thursday.

Flanked by Trump and top administration officials in the East Room, the secretary of Health and Human Services unveiled the first report of his "Make America Healthy Again" commission, formed by executive order to address Kennedy's core conviction: that unhealthy foods, too much prescription medication, and overreliance on vaccines are to blame for a chronic disease epidemic ravaging the country.

"This is a milestone," said Kennedy. "Never in American history has the federal government taken a position on public health like this."

The claims in the study, as well as its recommendations that focused on children's health, might seem familiar to any close observer of Kennedy. But the White House event, landing just before Kennedy marked 100 days in office last weekend, was the clearest demonstration so far of the significant authority Trump has

KENNEDY, Page A7

FEB. 13

Kennedy signals HHS will investigate antidepressant medications for minors

MARCH 28

Discloses he will reduce the HHS workforce by 10,000 employees

APRIL 6

Amid Texas outbreak, says vaccine is "most effective" way to stop measles

MAY 22

Releases first report of new "Make America Healthy Again" commission

MAY 27

Drops guidance for COVID boosters for healthy children and healthy pregnant people



Where does a critic go to eat?

Devra First reveals her favorite standbys that fit the bill when she's off the clock. **G1.**

Diverging from President Trump's stance, a small group of Republicans in Congress is escalating pressure on Russia for its aggression against Ukraine. **A3.**

Lewiston, Maine, will unveil a statue of Muhammad Ali to mark the 60th anniversary of his famous bout with Sonny Liston. **B1.**

NPR and three of its local stations sued President Trump, arguing that funding cuts violate free speech. **B5.**

Nicotine pouches are becoming more popular, despite health concerns. **B5.**

The birds (flip 'em!) and the be's (aggressive!)

It's time for that little talk with self-driving taxis about Boston

By Beth Teitell
GLOBE STAFF

Boston Drivers had just learned that Waymo self-driving taxis may be coming to town, and over on Reddit, the locals lost no time welcoming the prospective newcomers.

"I'm already enraged at the thought of being stuck behind one of these while it waits for the perfect moment to gradually merge," one Redditor wrote.

"K-Circle will bring the software to its knees," another predicted with glee, referring to the notorious Dorchester rotary. "There are no patterns to study, no rules to follow."

Word that Waymo would be mapping our streets broke earlier this month, and soon

people began spotting the vehicles around town. The cars are outfitted with cameras, radar, and lidar (a detection system that works on the principle of radar, but uses light from a laser) and are being driven — for now — by humans.

The goal, of course, is to gather data. And sure, facts about roads and whatever else Waymo uses to decide if a city's a good fit might help. In other places.

But is there a neural network deep enough to teach a robot to drive *here*? Never mind our snow, quirky street layout, and crazed delivery drivers. The bigger question is this: Can AI be taught to think with the twisted and

DRIVERS, Page A10